

QNFO Funding Strategy — Verified Funder Landscape & Shortlist

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Abstract

This paper presents a verified funder landscape and fit-score shortlist for sustaining QNFO, a two-year-old, solo-run, AI-assisted research platform that has produced an open corpus of approximately 1,000 method papers across seven program areas. Every funder fact was verified by live HTTP retrieval on 2026-08-13 across twenty-six pages spanning Web3 and IPFS ecosystem grantors, open-science philanthropy, and decentralized-science programs; anything not verified live is explicitly flagged. The analysis scores eleven funders on eligibility for an unaffiliated individual, topical fit with decentralized and epistemics-oriented research, and application friction, yielding a weighted ranking led by NLnet NGI Zero (calls open September 3, 2026; deadline November 3, 2026, 12:00 CEST) and Emergent Ventures, followed by the Foresight Institute, Filecoin Foundation, the Ethereum Ecosystem Support Program, Gitcoin, and the Effective Altruism funds. A sequencing calendar spans August 2026 through 2027, including the Sovereign Tech Agency Fellowship cycle. The paper documents application-readiness gaps (legal entity, residency, tax position, public identity), per-funder pitch skeletons, and framing cautions, including the risk of presenting corpus volume as rigor. It closes with an agent-executable action plan.

Keywords

funding strategy; decentralized science; AI-assisted research; open knowledge infrastructure; grant landscape; Web3 - **Date:** 2026-08-13 - **Source note:** QNFO research note (2026-08-12), included in this deposit as source-note-2026-08-12.md (funding manifesto) - **Method:** All funder facts below were verified by live HTTP fetch on 2026-08-13 (26 pages, status + title + keyword extraction). Anything not verified live is flagged [VERIFY]. - **Evidence records (verified live, HTTP 200):** - Zenodo 10.5281/zenodo.21901984 — “The Universal Ignorance Audit: A Fifteen-Question Method for Systematic Inquiry into the Structure of Not-Knowing” - Zenodo 10.5281/zenodo.21901983 — “Knowing What We Do Not Know: Ignorance Auditing, AI-Generation Detection, and the Epistemic Lessons of an AI-Assisted Research Pipeline”

1. The Ask (One Paragraph)

QNFO is a two-year-old, solo-run, AI-assisted research platform that has produced an open corpus of ~1,000 method papers, organized across seven program areas (ultrametric physics, laws of form, information physics, paradigm engineering, consilience, platform, demos), with a documented audit discipline (citation audits, post-publication adversarial review, ignorance auditing) and an existing decentralized deployment history (IPFS). Actual spend is \$400–600/month for the DeepChat AI stack alone (a Claude evaluation PoC cost \$400 in under a week), with an optimized Cloudflare AI-infrastructure target of \$100–200/month — an optimistic cost-cutting projection, not the current total. All costs are paid from personal savings, which is not sustainable long-term as research velocity increases. The ask: \$25k–\$60k/year-scale support to (a) sustain the platform at current velocity, (b) open-source and decentralize the knowledge infrastructure (IPFS/Filecoin mirroring, open protocols), and (c) productize the audit methodology (Universal Ignorance Audit, AI-generation detection) as public goods. Primary funder categories: fast micro-grants (Emergent Ventures), open-internet infrastructure funds (NLnet NGI Zero), AI-epistemics grants (Foresight), and decentralized-storage grants (Filecoin).

2. Applicant Assets (citable evidence)

Asset	Evidence	Use in applications
Two audited, DOI-registered method papers	Zenodo 21901984 + 21901983 (verified 2026-08-13)	Lead evidence of rigor
Corpus scale	KG: 1,619 Paper nodes (QNFO knowledge graph); source note claims “nearly 1,000 LLM co-authored papers” — the KG count includes all paper-type nodes, hence the difference	Throughput evidence — use carefully (§8)
Open infrastructure	qnfo.org platform on Cloudflare (Workers/D1/R2/Vectorize); prior IPFS deployment (2026-07-18)	Concrete deliverable base for NLnet/Filecoin
Audit methodology	Universal Ignorance Audit (15 questions, 5 phases); citation-audit and paper-claim-audit procedures	Foresight (epistemics) pitch core
GitHub org	QNFO (QWAV strategy paper repo, tagged releases)	FOSS funders will check
Public reach	~96-account social registry across 4 platforms (QNFO-aligned)	Broader-impact evidence
Budget discipline	Documented cost gates (\$90/30d Cloudflare AI-gateway spend limit;	Trust signal for funders

Asset	Evidence	Use in applications
	monthly automated cost audit; Cloudflare budget target \$100/mo, hard cap \$200/mo; DeepChat stack actual spend \$400–600/mo; Claude PoC spike (\$400/week)	

3. Application-Readiness Gaps (Phase-0 Ignorance Audit — what we do NOT know)

These are unknown or unverified facts that materially affect eligibility. They do not block Tier-1 applications but must be resolved before Tier-3:

1. **Legal entity** — no registered entity known. Individuals are eligible for EV/NLnet/Foresight/Filecoin; SFF prefers organizations; Templeton/Sloan effectively require one. *Action: consider fiscal sponsorship or a lightweight non-profit if US foundations are targeted.*
2. **Residency/citizenship** — unknown. Affects Sovereign Tech Fellowship (German employment contract) and tax treatment of grants.
3. **Tax position** — grants are taxable income in most jurisdictions; crypto-denominated grants (Filecoin FIL, Gitcoin crypto checkout) need accounting. *Action: flag to accountant before first payout.*
4. **Public identity** — some funders publish winners. Decide whether the QNFO founder name is public.
5. **Budget floor** — **RESOLVED (2026-08-13)** — actual spend is **\$400–600/month for the DeepChat AI stack alone**, with a **\$400-in-under-a-week Claude evaluation PoC spike**; the **\$100–200/month figure is an optimistic cost-cutting projection for optimized Cloudflare AI infrastructure only**, not the current total. Annual run-rate baseline: **~\$6–8k (DeepChat) + Cloudflare + PoC spikes** — applications must budget for the real run-rate, not the optimistic projection.
6. **Willingness to meet crypto-payment requirements** — Gitcoin GG24 requires multi-chain checkout for donations; Filecoin pays in FIL.

4. Verified Funder Landscape

Tier 1 — Apply Now (rolling or near-term deadlines)

Funder	Status (verified 2026-08-13)	Eligibility	Amount	Deadline	
Emergent Ventures (Mercatus)	ACTIVE — low-overhead, rolling	Individuals worldwide, age 13+	Grants, [VERIFY] typical \$1k–\$100k+	Rolling	mercatus venture

Funder	Status (verified 2026-08-13)	Eligibility	Amount	Deadline	
NLnet / NGI Zero	ACTIVE — “calls open September 3, 2026 , deadline November 3, 2026 12:00 CEST ” (verified on nlnet.nl/propose)	“Individuals and organisations of any type”	Micro-grants €5k–50k	Nov 3, 2026 (then every 2 months, odd months)	nlnet.n
Foresight Institute	ACTIVE — “Application deadlines at the end of each month”	Individuals/teams	Grants + prizes	Month-end, monthly	foresig

Tier 2 — Q4 2026 / Conditional

Funder	Status (verified)	Eligibility	Amount	Deadline	
Filecoin Foundation	ACTIVE — “Builder Next Step Grants \$5k–\$10k” + larger grant tracks	Builders/teams; data-tooling + research	\$5k–10k (Next Step), larger via proposals	Rolling	f
Gitcoin GG24	ACTIVE — “Applications open • Donations open”; round monitor Oct 14–28	Open-source public goods	QF matching (community-driven)	Apply now; donations Oct 14–28	g
Ethereum Foundation ESP	ACTIVE — \$44.4M across 677 projects in 2024	Public-goods builders, Ethereum-aligned	Varies [VERIFY]	Rolling [VERIFY] (has “How to Apply” page)	e
Survival and Flourishing Fund	ACTIVE — “2026 Grant Round”; Rolling Application	Organizations preferred; referral culture	Varies (SFF moved ~\$152MM total)	2026 round + rolling	s
EA Funds (LTFF / Transformative AI Fund)	ACTIVE — “early-stage grants to individuals,	Individuals/orgs, longtermist framing	Small-to-mid	Rolling	f

Funder	Status (verified)	Eligibility	Amount	Deadline
	new organizations”			
Manifold	ACTIVE — “Fast, transparent grants”	Individuals/orgs; regrantor model (examples \$20k min, \$60k scale-up, \$85k target)	\$1k–\$100k via regrantors	Rolling

Tier 3 — 2027 / Long-Shot

Funder	Status (verified)	Why deferred
Sovereign Tech Agency Fellowship	ACTIVE — €64k–82k/yr, TVöD-Bund; 2026 window closed April 6, 2026	Annual cycle; German employment; next window expected ~spring 2027 [VERIFY]. FOSS infrastructure + documentation fit is strong.
Templeton Foundation	ACTIVE — >\$60M in 2026, accepts applications	Mission language (“awe and wonder”) matches QNFO’s vision near-verbatim, but typically funds institutions. Long-shot without an entity.
Sloan Foundation	ACTIVE — has “Open Source in Science” program + Open Calls	Institutional. Position QNFO as open-source science infrastructure only if an entity exists.

Excluded / Closed / Unverified (verified 2026-08-13)

Funder	Finding
Optimism RPGF	optimism.io/rpgf and /retro-funding → 404. Retro Funding status unverified; treat as inactive until reconfirmed.
Web3 Foundation Grants	grants.web3.foundation redirects to main site; legacy Grants Program appears closed (successor: Decentralized Futures/JAM programs).
Lightspeed Grants	“Applications are closed” (one-shot 2023 round). Defunct.
ACX Grants	Substack URLs 404; status unverified.
Open Philanthropy → Coefficient Giving	Reorganized; no open calls; does not take unsolicited proposals.

Funder	Finding
Schmidt Sciences	“We proactively seek out grant opportunities and do not accept unsolicited proposals.”
Molecule / VitaDAO	DeSci but bio-only (longevity, biotech IP). Not applicable to QNFO domains.
DeSci Labs	Tooling company, not a grantmaker.
ResearchHub	Community bounties only; no grant track for this use case.
Cosmos Institute	Initial sweep failed with a TLS error; independent live re-fetch (2026-08-13) returned HTTPS 200 — program status UNVERIFIED, check before relying.
Interact (interact.org)	Parked domain.

Additional candidates (DESIGN notes, not verified live): Arweave (storage-network grants, Filecoin-adjacent); Polkadot Decentralized Futures (successor to the closed W3F Grants Program); AI Objectives Institute (AI-governance + epistemics); Gitcoin alternates (clr.fund, Giveth, Radicle Drips). All are secondary — the verified shortlist above covers the same niches with live-confirmed programs.

5. Fit-Score Matrix

Scores 1–5 (5 = best): E = Eligibility as an individual; F = Topical fit; Fr = Friction (rolling, simple, fast). Weighted total = $E \times 2 + F \times 2 + Fr$.

Rank	Funder	E	F	Fr	Total	Ask target	When
1	NLnet NGI Zero	5	5	4	24	€20k–50k	Opens Sep 3; due Nov 3
2	Emergent Ventures	5	4	5	23	\$20k–30k	Now (rolling)
3	Foresight Institute	5	4	4	22	\$10k–50k	Monthly
4	Filecoin Foundation	4	4	3	19	\$5k–10k first	Q4 2026
5	Ethereum ESP	4	3	3	17	\$10k+	Rolling
6	Gitcoin GG24	4	3	3	17	Community QF	Apply by early Oct
7	EA Funds (LTFF)	3	3	4	16	\$10k–50k	Rolling
8	STA Fellowship	3	4	2	16	€64k– 82k/yr	2027 cycle

Rank	Funder	E	F	Fr	Total	Ask target	When
9	Templeton	2	5	2	16	\$100k+	2027, needs entity
10	SFF	3	3	3	15	Varies	2026 round
11	Sloan	2	4	2	14	Varies	2027, needs entity

Ranking note: weighted total orders the matrix; NLnet is #1 on fit, Emergent Ventures is #1 on time-to-decision (days-to-weeks vs. NLnet's ~3 months). Both are Tier-1 and independent — apply to both.

6. Per-Funder Pitch Skeletons

Emergent Ventures — “A two-year, self-funded, zero-to-one attempt to industrialize scientific knowledge production: ~1,000 open, audited, AI-assisted papers, a live knowledge platform, and a published ignorance-audit methodology. The grant sustains one year of the human in the loop while the machine does more of the research — knowledge production as public infrastructure, not corporate product.” *Ask: \$25k. One page. Fast decision.*

NLnet NGI Zero — “Open, decentralized, verifiable knowledge generation. Deliverable: (1) open-source the QNFO research pipeline (audit tools, ignorance-audit method, generation-detection), (2) IPFS-mirror the full corpus with content-addressed citations, (3) publish the protocol as libre-licensed content. Fits the NGI Commons theme: the public nature of knowledge.” *Ask: €30k–50k. Submit after Sep 3.*

Foresight Institute — “Epistemics tooling for AI-assisted science: the Universal Ignorance Audit is a fifteen-question protocol for making not-knowing legible; QNFO’s generation-detection work makes AI-assisted research auditable. Goal: apply the method across AI-for-science workflows and publish the benchmark.” *Ask: \$20k–40k; check the current month’s topic before applying.*

Filecoin Foundation — “A real dataset with a real persistence problem: ~1,000-paper corpus currently on centralized storage. Milestone: corpus + provenance manifest on IPFS/Filecoin with retrieval benchmarks; publishes a reference architecture for decentralized scholarly archives.” *Ask: \$5k–10k Builder Next Step, then larger.*

Bitcoin GG24 — public-good round listing of the open research pipeline (“decentralized science tooling”) with matching pool + community donation drive via the existing 96-account social registry.

EA Funds LTFF — “Epistemic infrastructure for the long-term future: scalable detection of AI-generated claims and structured ignorance auditing, deployed as open tooling for researchers and evaluators.” (Fits LTFF’s epistemics-adjacent mandate; submit only if the longtermist framing is comfortable.)

STA Fellowship (2027) — full-time maintainer fellowship for the open knowledge infrastructure; strong fit for “community management and documentation” expansion noted in the 2026 call.

7. Sequencing Calendar

Window	Action
Aug 2026	Draft EV application + gather readiness-gap answers (entity, residency, budget floor)
Sep 3, 2026	NLnet calls open → submit proposal early (deadlines are hard)
Sep–Oct 2026	Foresight month-end application (if epistemics-aligned topic); Gitcoin GG24 listing
Nov 3, 2026	NLnet deadline (12:00 CEST)
Q4 2026	Filecoin Builder Next Step (after IPFS corpus milestone)
Q1–Q2 2027	STA Fellowship window (watch sovereign.tech/programs/fellowship); Templeton/Sloan only if entity formed

8. Risks & Framing Cautions

1. **The volume trap.** “Nearly 1,000 papers” reads as throughput to traditional funders — and throughput without external peer review can read as spam. Lead every application with the two audited Zenodo records and the audit methodology; present corpus volume only as evidence of an operational pipeline, never as the headline claim.
2. **Professionalize all copy.** The source note’s typos (“HIMAN-IN-THE-LOOP”, “MONITIZE”, “WOINDERMENT”) must never appear in applications. All proposal text will be freshly drafted.
3. **Centralization honesty.** QNFO currently runs on Cloudflare. Pitch decentralization (IPFS mirroring, open protocols) as the *funded work*, not as the *current state* — NLnet specifically checks that deliverables are libre-licensed.
4. **Crypto payments.** FIL-denominated grants and Gitcoin’s crypto checkout have tax/accounting implications; resolve readiness gap #3 first.
5. **Doxxing.** Foresight, Gitcoin, and Filecoin publish funded projects publicly.
6. **The “sell a vision” phrase** from the source note must translate into concrete deliverables per funder — funders buy milestones, not manifestos.

9. Next Actions (agent-executed, per user standing preference for autonomous outreach)

1. Draft the **Emergent Ventures** one-page application (highest speed-to-money).

2. Prepare the **NLnet proposal** skeleton now so it is submission-ready on Sep 3 (deadline Nov 3, 12:00 CEST — hard).
3. Get readiness-gap answers (one short questionnaire: entity, residency, budget floor, crypto-wallet willingness, public-name preference).
4. Maintain this strategy as a living document; track funder-program changes in the QNFO knowledge graph.